Salem Witch Trials Collection

By Nicole Cooley

INTRODUCTION

By the end of 1692, twenty individuals were executed and more than 150 imprisoned -- almost all of them as a result of spectral evidence. The historical body of evidence that remains from the Salem witch trials of 1692 touched the hands, mind, and imagination of poet Nicole Cooley, compelling her to seek entry to an inaccessible past of lies. Cooley's poems form a remarkable narrative, one that displays the enormous cultural power the Salem witch trials retain in twenty-first-century America.

We first look to the family of Cotton Mather. He was the son of famed minister and Harvard President, Increase Mather, and grandson of Minister Richard Mather, and spoke out against spectral evidence. He felt it was unreliable because the Devil could take the form of an innocent person to do his evil deeds. Unfortunately, his cautionary words were not enough to stop the madness. The Mather Boys: Richard, Increase, Cotton

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4NG Fanatics

The one who starts it: who first crosses the cold lead ocean
to settle in this land
The one who prays and fasts in secret for God to untie his
tongue
The one who waits all day in his study for proof of Election
or at least a Remedy
The one whose ship is driven against the white rocks at the
edge of Isle of Shoals
The one with an Infirmity in his Speech, each word splitting
open in his mouth
The one who leaves his study only for meals or Family
Prayer
The one whose hand crosses the page again and again,
practicing words he cannot say
The one who holds *The Book of Martyrs* on the ship's
slick deck as anchor cables snap, sails rip from masts

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4NG Fanatics

The one who explains that *Strong affections bring strong*
afflictions and shuts his study door, his son standing
alone outside
The son who dreams his grandfather's voyage, who reads
his father's prayers, who will write the future down:
It is a world all over defiled with Sin, God will shortly
burn it for a Witch

TRANSITION

And the cultural turmoil known as the Salem Witch Trials begins . . . . . when Margaret Jacobs penned the following from Salem prison on August 21, 1962 . . . I enjoy, though in abundance of afflictions, being close confined here in a loathsome dungeon. Witness, Recantation.

Witness, Recantation

Honored Father, when I remember you
your eyes turn the color of a bruise.
As soon as you speak to me you disappear,
and I have to imagine
the ocean that might lie between us,
then something breaks inside my body
and everyone I've hurt returns:
Grandfather, Mother, You,
skin translucent like the oiled paper
we stretched in place of glass
between the window lead.
I see through your body. You never
have to say it: Lying is a sin.
What's worse to you, false testimony
or a wrong confession? Down here is all
darkness, the only sound the slur
of rain in the dirt, water rats scratching
inside the walls. Grandfather is dead.
Mother locked in Boston Jail. You
escaped. Lying is a sin. Just as any telling
of this story is a lie,
just as in the future,
years from now when you and I are dead,
another woman will write this letter down

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in a room with sky-colored walls
and electric candles under a water-
color of the sea, waves capped in white
like dress lace, a girl on the dock waving
goodbye to no one under the caption:
Salem, Massachusetts, New England's Maritime
Paradise.

TRANSITION

The atrocities continued in the name of religion, the lord, and righteousness . . . According to the diary of Samuel Sewall (September 19, 1962) it was about noon, at Salem, when Giles Corey was press'd to death for standing Mute. The girls' testimony is gravel scattered on the grass.
Testimony: He or His Apparition

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Ann Putnam: Giles Corey or his Apperance has most
greviously afflected me by beating pinching and almost
Choaking me to death
Inside the meetinghouse each afflicted girl repeats the
next.

4N6 Fanatics

Mercy Lewis: I veryly beleve in my heart that Giles Cory
is a dreadfull wizzard for sence he had ben in prison
he
or his Apperance has come and most greviously
tormented me
The copier flattens the page, hammers down identical
speech.
Sarah Bibber: I have ben most greviously affleted by
giles
Cory or his Appearance
But the man won't speak to defend or plead. He sits still
and
silent in his pew.
Mary Warren: At the time of his examination I saw: s'd
Cory or his appearition most: dredfully afflect: Mary
Walcot An putnam. Mercy lewes & Sarah Vibber
The morning of his execution: the meetinghouse floods
with
light.
Outside a circle rises around the punished man:
the magistrates pile stone after stone on his ribs to

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crush

him into speech.

Nobody can see the lesson: nothing can drive the voice

out of the body.

TRANSITION

Perhaps the most disturbing documented Salem Witch Trial involved the story of little Dorothy "Dorcas" Good, a four-year-old imprisoned with her mother as a witch. Years later, her father tried to sue the government of Salem, saying that Dorcas was so unhinged as a result of the 8 months she spent in prison - including watching her mother carried off to the gallows and seeing her newborn sister die, that she was useless to him and "unable to govern herself." Dorcas' story is horrible and tragic. The Mother Dorcas Good.

The Mother: Dorcas Good

Snow fills the fields like milk.

Inside the Meeting House I wait on the communion

table.

I unbutton my muslin dress while the Reverend reads

To the Marshall of Essex or his Deputy:

You are in their Magistrates' names hereby required

4NG Fanatics

To bring before us Dorcus Good.

I am four years old. My dress drops from my body.

The three girls circle, calling

The mother, the mother, holding their throats with

their hands.

I close my eyes: I'm outside in the snow,

Standing in the harbor's dark throat we followed

Here, to the New Jerusalem.

Or I'm with my mother in Ipswich Jail.

The Reverend holds a candle close

To each girl's wrist, to the teeth marks in a row,

Like tine stitches, they say are mine.

In jail, my mother pulls

Me into her lap, cradles my head against her chest

As my mouth reaches for her nipple.

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Here is the Devil's Mark, the Reverend raises
My hand for all to see. A small red bite.
A perfect circle on my palm.

Did a yellow bird suck here between your fingers?

I close my eyes
And the bird spreads its wings
On my mother's shoulders, hiding us, keeping us safe.

Now, Child, repeat the prayer.
On the table, my arms stretched out:
Our Father, Which Art in Heaven, Hallowed Be They Name.

I could be a bird. The girls still circle.
When I look at them they fall against each other
Like the rag dolls my mother arranged on my bed at home.

4NG Fanatics

I want to be invisible.
I want to go back to my mother's body.

Branches snap off the black tress on Gallows hill.
Ice cracks on the roof of the jail.
This girl is a witch. The men in the front pew nod.

The girls let go of their throats.
Does my mother sleep in jail alone? I want to call to her.
I can't. My body stands straight and still on the examining table,
My voice torn out –

SOURCE INFORMATION

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